

able balance, and FEEs are equal to underhanded tactics. The industry calls fees their way of making money. I call it criminal.

The New Targets

The gazillions of dollars of profits that the consumer lending industry is currently making is not enough for them. They are now tapping into markets that, only a few years ago, the industry leaders would have thought pointless, lacking potential, and a total waste of their time. The new attitude is predatory, and the credit card companies are stalking new prey: college students, the impoverished with poor or no credit history, and illegal aliens.

Exploiting Illegal Aliens

The *Wall Street Journal* front page story on February 13, 2007, revealed that Bank of America has a new credit card, especially and exclusively for immigrants – aliens who are here illegally and/or have no credit record or Social Security number. Bank executives insist that they are doing nothing wrong, and technically, they have not broken any laws – they're just working the legal loopholes. Behind closed doors, I imagine they feel smug that they are the first to get their fingers in the wallets of the eleven million undocumented immigrants. Someone probably got a raise for thinking of it. They maintain that they are in compliance with all U.S. banking and antiterrorism laws. Illegal immigrants can go to the Mexican consulate and get a *matrícula consular*, an identification card that allows aliens to open bank accounts. An article on BusinessWeek.com quotes a bank branch manager stating that *matrícula* holders are “bringing us all the money that has been under the mattress.”

The credit
card industry
has spun out
of control.

But I doubt that Bank of America has considered the ramifications of their new program, or that they really care. They have opened Pandora's box, and all they care about is that they have a new group of people to lay their fees on. When dollar signs are in their eyes, it is hard to see anything else.